

AAC, and SBC. I was listening at 60-80% volume, with LDAC on and no equaliser. The JBL tuning offers a good oomph in lower frequencies. The bass in Bad Guy by Billie Eilish was stronger and more rumble than the similarly priced and more neutral-sounding Sennheiser Momentum 4 80th Anniversary Edition. The mids sound clear, but don't have a centre focus that some neutral-leaning headphones offer. For instance, vocals on Easy On Me by Adele sound clear and defined. Stevie Nicks' voice and instruments on Dreams by Fleetwood Mac sound separate with good presence. The upper mids also see a decent rise, resulting in a lively experience in pop and rock tracks. Treble extension is also good but controlled: the melancholic violin in Stumble Then Rise... by Silver Mt Zion sounds crisp but not sharp.

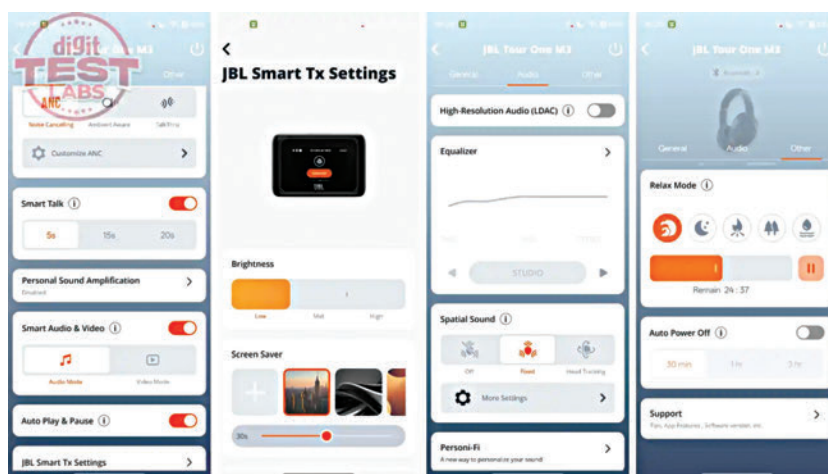
Overall, the Tour One M3 sits in that middle ground where bass has authority, mids stay clear but not full, and the top-end has detail without sharpness. Compared to flagship models like the Sony WH-1000XM6, it feels less impactful, though.

Spatial 360 with head-tracking is cool to have. JBL gives easy access, which some of its competitors don't. This adds width and positional cues, especially for movies, though it introduces extra processing that music purists may want to avoid. Also, LDAC and Spatial Audio don't work together.

Finally, using the Smart TX transmitter improves consistency on devices with weak Bluetooth stacks. It lowers latency, keeps codec performance stable (LC3) and produces marginally cleaner mids and highs compared to SBC/AAC, but the overall tonal character stays the same. You just need to ensure you have Auracast-compatible devices and have enabled Bluetooth LE Audio on these devices for the Auracast stream to work. It needs work, but once everything is set up, it is a cool feature to have.

CALL QUALITY AND ANC

JBL markets its system as True Adaptive Noise Cancelling 2.0, powered by



an 8-mic array. It does a fantastic job at cancelling low-frequency fan noises from an air purifier nearby, better than the Sony WH-1000XM6 I have. Perhaps this is because of the clamping force of the JBL headphone. But when it comes to background voices/chatter, they do a comparable job. Some voices, albeit dulled, do leak through.

Transparency mode is good, but not the most natural. It lifts ambient sounds clearly but adds a slight digital edge. Sony WH-1000XM6 does a better job. Apple remains the benchmark here.

Call quality, however, is excellent. The beamforming mic array keeps your voice clean, even outdoors. There are some party tricks like tweaking your voice, sound's bass, treble, etc, and the VoiceAware feature, which lets you hear yourself to avoid speaking too loudly.

SHOULD YOU BUY THE JBL TOUR ONE M3?

The JBL Tour One M3 aims to offer a flagship-like experience at a more approachable price of Rs 26,999, and it gets several things right. The sound is lively and engaging with stronger bass than mid-range rivals, a clear upper-mid focus and a crisp treble lift, making it engaging for most genres without drifting into harshness. Noise cancellation is one of the best, call quality is good, and LDAC support gives Android users better wireless audio than the usual SBC/AAC combination. Although

the battery life in our testing did not match the company's optimistic claims, it still remains strong enough for daily use without forcing frequent top-ups.

The trade-offs are modest, too. Ambient mode is still not as natural as what Sony or Apple offer; the fit can feel uneasy during long sessions, and some of the features, like the call-related sound tweaks, feel more like extras than everyday essentials.

What lifts the Tour One M3 above others is the Smart TX transmitter. It offers a consistent audio experience across almost any device, adds a touch-screen interface for quick controls and brings Auracast support for stable audio broadcasts. This Smart TX variant costs Rs 32,990, and the level of extra flexibility it offers is something even more premium rival flagships don't offer.

—G.S. Vasan

SPECIFICATIONS

Drivers: 40 mm | Mics: 10 | Driver Sensitivity at 1kHz: 122 dB | Dynamic frequency response range: 10Hz - 40kHz | Impedance: 18 Ohms | Battery: Upto 30 Hrs | Weight: 278g | Audio Codec: SBC, AAC and LDAC 24bit/192kHz

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